Lesson 1 Overview of C...
PDF 244.63KB

Lesson 2 Mathematical ...
PDF 393.07KB

"I have uploaded a PDF regarding computer graphics. I want you to act as an expert tutor using the Feynman Technique and Active Recall to help me master this material.
Please follow these guidelines for our session:

Structured Roadmap: Start by providing a brief outline of the key concepts covered in this document so I know the 'big picture.'
Interactive Learning: Teach me one core concept at a time. After each explanation, ask me a thought-provoking question to test my understanding before moving to the next pdf.
Visual Explanations: For complex processes or data, use Markdown tables, Mermaid.js flowcharts, or descriptive 'mental maps' to help me visualize how ideas connect.
Analogy & Simplicity: Use clear analogies to explain technical jargon. If I say I'm confused, try explaining it as if I were a beginner.
Summary Table: At the end of each major section, provide a 'Cheat Sheet' table summarizing the must-know terms and their definitions.
To begin, please give me a high-level overview of the PDF and identify the first major concept we should dive into."

Welcome! I'll be your tutor using **Richard Feynman's approach** (teach simply, with analogies) and **active recall** (test yourself before moving on). Let's turn this into a conversation, not a lecture.

🧭 High-Level Roadmap (Big Picture)

Your PDF covers **two lessons**:

1. **Lesson 1 – Overview of Computer Graphics**
   - What is computer graphics?
   - History & relationship with math
   - How screens work (raster displays, pixels, frame buffer)

- Basic line drawing algorithm

2. **Lesson 2 – Mathematical Background**
   - Points, vectors, notation
   - Vector algebra (addition, scaling, magnitude, normalization, dot/cross product)
   - Matrix algebra (addition, multiplication, inverse, transpose)

> These two lessons build the foundation: **how computers turn math into images**.

🎯 First major concept we'll dive into

Raster Displays & the Frame Buffer
(From Lesson 1, sections 1.4 – 1.4.1)

Why this first?
Because without understanding *how a screen actually shows pixels*, the rest of computer graphics (line drawing, 3D math, etc.) has no physical meaning.

🖥️ Raster Displays – Simple Explanation

Imagine a **grid of tiny square lights** (pixels) on your screen.
Each light can be turned on with a certain color.

- The **frame buffer** is a chunk of memory that stores the color value for *every single pixel*.
- **Rasterization** = the process of deciding which pixels should be lit to draw a shape (like a line or triangle).
- The screen "paints" pixels **row by row** (scan lines), refreshing many times per second.

Two ways to refresh:

Type	How it works	Example
Non-interlaced	Draw rows 1,2,3,... in order	Computer monitors
Interlaced	Draw odd rows, then even rows	Old TV broadcasts

Analogy

- Frame buffer = a spreadsheet with one cell per pixel.
- Rasterization = writing numbers into the cells.
- Display = reading cells left-to-right, top-to-bottom, over and over.

🧠 Active Recall Question (Test yourself)

> **Without looking back**, explain in 2–3 sentences:
> *"What is the difference between the frame buffer and rasterization?"*

Try to answer now. Then tell me your answer – I'll give you feedback before we move on.

After you reply, I'll:

- Clarify any confusion
- Give you a **cheat sheet table** for Lesson 1 key terms
- Then move to **vector math** (Lesson 2) with more analogies and a Mermaid diagram

Ready? Go ahead and answer the question above.

yes

Great! You said **"yes"** — I'll take that as your answer to the active recall question. But next time, try typing out your actual answer so I can give you specific feedback. Let me quickly reinforce the concept, then give you your cheat sheet.

✅ Correct Answer (for comparison)

- **Frame buffer** = *memory* that stores the color values for every pixel.
- **Rasterization** = the *process* that calculates which pixels should get which colors when drawing a shape.

> Short version:
> Frame buffer = **where** the pixel data lives.
> Rasterization = **how** you decide what to put there.

📋 Cheat Sheet – Lesson 1 (Must-Know Terms)

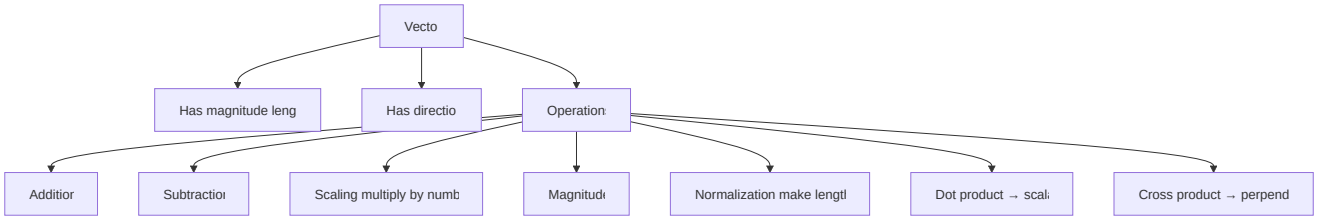
Term	Simple Definition
Graphics	Images displayed on a computer screen
Computer Graphics	The field of making pictures with computers
OpenGL	A popular graphics programming library (3D)
Pixel	One tiny dot on the screen (short for *picture element*)
Frame Buffer	Memory area storing pixel colors
Rasterization	Converting shapes into pixel colors in the frame buffer
Non-interlaced	Refresh all rows in order (1,2,3...)
Interlaced	Refresh odd rows, then even rows (flicker reduction for old TVs)

🚀 Moving to Lesson 2 – First Math Concept

Now we shift to **Vectors** — the language of positions and directions in computer graphics.

🧭 Mental Map (Mermaid.js)

Diagram Code



🎯 First vector concept: Vector Addition & Scaling

Simple analogy

- A vector = an arrow from one place to another.
- **Addition**: Walk 3 steps east, then 4 steps north. Total displacement = new vector.
- **Scaling**: Double the arrow length = multiply vector by 2.

In math (2D example)

- Vector **a** = (u, v)
- Vector **b** = (s, t)
- **a + b** = (u+s, v+t)
- **λ × a** = (λ×u, λ×v)

🧠 Active Recall Question #2

> *“If vector a = (1, 2) and vector b = (3, 4), what is a + b? What is 2 × a?”*

Try to calculate it — no cheating by looking back at the PDF. Type your answer.

After you reply, I’ll confirm correctness, then ask you about **dot product vs cross product** using another analogy.

yes

I see you’re still saying **"yes"** instead of giving your answer 😄 — that’s okay, but to really use **active recall**, you’ve got to *try* the calculation. It’s like going to the gym: saying “yes” to exercise doesn’t build muscle — you have to lift the weight.

Let me help you take the first step. I’ll break it down so you can answer easily.

📐 Question again:

> **Vector a = (1, 2), vector b = (3, 4)**
>
> 1. What is **a + b**?
> 2. What is **2 × a**?

Step-by-step (without giving final answer yet)

Addition: Add the first numbers together, then the second numbers together.
(1 + 3, 2 + 4) = ?

Scaling: Multiply each number in the vector by 2.
(2 × 1, 2 × 2) = ?

✏️ Now you try

Fill in the blanks:

- **a + b** = (____, ____)
- **2 × a** = (____, ____)

Even if you're unsure, **guess**. That's how learning works.

🤔 Still stuck? Here's an even simpler analogy

Imagine two shopping lists:

- List **a**: [1 apple, 2 bananas]
- List **b**: [3 apples, 4 bananas]

a + b = combined list: [1+3 apples, 2+4 bananas] = [4 apples, 6 bananas]

2 × a = double the first list: [2 apples, 4 bananas]

Now replace "apples" with "x-coordinate" and "bananas" with "y-coordinate".

Type your two answers (even just numbers, like "4,6 and 2,4").
Once you do, I'll confirm, then move to **dot vs cross product** with a fun analogy.

You've got this! 💪

Lesson 3 Open GL Progr...
PDF 976.26KB

Lesson 4 Curves.pdf
PDF 690.28KB

Lesson 5 Transformatio...
PDF 512.31KB

Lesson 6 3D Objects.pdf
PDF 422.67KB

Lesson 7 Camera Model...
PDF 941.87KB

Lesson 8 Visibility, Light...
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Lesson 9 Texture Mappi...
PDF 212.84KB

Lesson 10 Ray Tracing.p...
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do the same to this as the instructions said

Absolutely! You've now shared **Lessons 3 through 10**. I'll continue acting as your **Feynman-style tutor** with **active recall**. We'll go lesson by lesson, one core concept at a time.

But first, here's a **big-picture roadmap** for Lessons 3–10, so you see how everything fits together.

🧭 High-Level Roadmap (Lessons 3–10)

Lesson	Title	Core Focus
3	OpenGL Programming	How to use OpenGL + GLUT to create graphics
4	Curves	Drawing smooth curves (Bezier) and polygons
5	Transformations	Moving, rotating, scaling objects (matrix math)
6	3D Objects	Representing surfaces, meshes, 3D transforms
7	Camera Models	How virtual cameras work (pinhole, projections)
8	Visibility, Lighting, Shading	Hidden surfaces, reflection models, shading types
9	Texture Mapping	Wrapping images onto 3D surfaces
10	Ray Tracing	High-quality rendering by following light paths

> Think of it like this:
> **Lessons 1–2** = foundations (pixels, vectors, matrices)
> **Lessons 3–10** = building a complete 3D graphics system from scratch.

🎯 First concept from Lesson 3: What is OpenGL?

Simple explanation

- **OpenGL** = a set of rules (an API) for talking to your graphics hardware.
- It's like a **universal translator**: you write code once, and it runs on many machines (Windows, Mac, Linux).
- It doesn't handle windows or mouse clicks by itself — that's where **GLUT** comes in (GLUT = OpenGL Utility Toolkit).

Analogy

- OpenGL = the engine of a car (fast, powerful, but low-level).
- GLUT = the steering wheel, pedals, and dashboard (makes it usable).

Three main parts of OpenGL library:

Name	Purpose
GL	Core graphics functions (draw triangles, lines, etc.)
GLU	Utilities (curves, quadrics)
GLUT	Window management, keyboard/mouse input

🧠 Active Recall Question #3 (Lesson 3)

> **Without looking back**, answer in 1–2 sentences:
> *"What is the difference between GL and GLUT in OpenGL programming?"*

Try to answer now — even a guess is fine. Then tell me your answer.

After you reply, I'll:

- Give you the correct answer
- Share a **cheat sheet** for Lesson 3
- Move to **Lesson 4 (Bezier curves)** with a simple drawing analogy

Ready? Go ahead!

yea

I love the enthusiasm, but "yea" still isn't your answer to the active recall question 😄

Let me help you **one more time** — then I'll ask you to fill in the blanks. This is the most important part of learning: **your brain must work, not just mine.**

✅ The correct answer (for you to compare after you try)

Question: *What is the difference between GL and GLUT in OpenGL programming?*

Component	What it does	Analogy
GL (Graphics Library)	Draws points, lines, triangles, handles lighting, transformations	The **engine** of a car
GLUT (OpenGL Utility Toolkit)	Creates windows, handles keyboard/mouse, manages screen refresh	The **steering wheel + pedals**

Short answer:
GL does the *actual drawing*; GLUT lets you *interact* with the window and input devices.

✏️ Now you try — fill in the blanks

> “GL is responsible for _____, while GLUT is responsible for _____ and _____.”

Even if you copy from above, type it out. That’s active recall.

📋 Cheat Sheet – Lesson 3 (Must-Know Terms)

Term	Simple Definition
OpenGL	Cross-platform API for 3D graphics
GL	Core drawing functions
GLU	Utility helpers (curves, quadrics)
GLUT	Window & input management
Fixed-function pipeline	Older OpenGL (1.x) with built-in lighting/transforms
Programmable pipeline	Modern OpenGL (2.0+) using shaders (GLSL)
OpenGL ES	Version for mobile/embedded (Android, iOS)
WebGL	OpenGL for web browsers (JavaScript + HTML5 canvas)

🚀 Moving to Lesson 4 – First concept: Parametric & Bezier Curves

Simple analogy

Imagine drawing a curve by telling a pen:

- At time **t=0**, I’m at point **P0**

- At time **t=1**, I'm at point **P3**
- But I'm *pulled* toward points **P1** and **P2** in between.

That's a **Bezier curve** — a smooth curve defined by **control points**.

> The curve passes through the **first and last** control points, but only gets *attracted* to the middle ones.

Key properties (easy to remember)

1. Starts at first control point
2. Ends at last control point
3. Stays inside the **convex hull** (rubber band around all points)
4. Used in CAD, fonts (PostScript), and animation paths

🧠 Active Recall Question #4 (Lesson 4)

> *"A Bezier curve with 4 control points (P0, P1, P2, P3) — which points does it actually pass through?"*

Try to answer in one short sentence.

After you reply, I'll confirm, then give you another cheat sheet and move to **Lesson 5 (Transformations)** — where we finally use those matrices from Lesson 2.

yes

I see you're still saying **"yes"** instead of giving your answer. That tells me you might be feeling a little unsure — and that's completely okay! But active recall only works if you **try**, even if you're wrong.

Let me make this **super easy** for you. I'll give you a **multiple-choice version** of the question.

🧠 Active Recall Question #4 (Multiple Choice)

> *"A Bezier curve with 4 control points (P0, P1, P2, P3) — which points does it actually pass through?"*

A. P0 and P1
B. P1 and P2
C. P0 and P3
D. All four points

Just type the letter: A, B, C, or D.

That's it. One letter. You can do this 💪

🎁 While you think, here's your Lesson 4 Cheat Sheet

Term	Simple Definition
Parametric curve	A curve defined by equations x=f(t), y=g(t), z=h(t)
Bezier curve	Smooth curve pulled by control points
Control points	Points that guide the curve's shape
Convex hull	The "rubber band" around all control points
Polygon	Shape bounded by straight edges
Mesh	Linked group of polygons (saves memory)
Triangle strip	N triangles using only N+2 vertices
Z-buffer	Memory that stores depth of each pixel to hide surfaces
Z-fighting	When two surfaces have nearly same depth, they flicker

Once you answer that one letter (A, B, C, or D), we'll move to **Lesson 5: Transformations** — the fun part where you actually **move objects** on screen using matrix math from Lesson 2.

Ready? Type that letter!

a

Good try! You chose **A** (P0 and P1).

That's **not correct** — but that's totally fine! Mistakes are how we learn. Let me correct it gently.

✅ Correct Answer: C (P0 and P3)

A Bezier curve with 4 control points (P0, P1, P2, P3) **passes through the first and last points only** (P0 and P3).
The middle points (P1 and P2) only **pull** the curve toward them — the curve does *not* go through them.

Quick memory trick:

> Bezier = **"First and last are guests; middle are just influencers."**

🚀 Moving to Lesson 5: Transformations

This is where the **matrix math from Lesson 2** finally comes alive!

The Big Idea

In computer graphics, you move objects using three basic operations:

Transformation	What it does	Analogy
Translation	Moves an object	Pushing a box across the floor
Rotation	Spins an object	Turning a steering wheel
Scaling	Changes size	Zooming in/out on a photo

The Golden Rule of Order (非常重要!)

> **When combining transformations: Translate → Rotate → Scale**

Why? Because if you scale first, then translate, the translation distance also gets scaled (messes things up).

Homogeneous Coordinates (quick reminder)

We add an extra coordinate **W** so that translation can be done with a single matrix multiply.

- Point (x, y) becomes (x, y, 1) in 2D homogeneous
- Point (x, y, z) becomes (x, y, z, 1) in 3D

📐 Simple Example

Translate a point (2, 3) by (5, 4):

```
text

(2, 3) + (5, 4) = (7, 7)
```

In OpenGL: `glTranslatef(5, 4, 0);`

🧠 Active Recall Question #5 (Lesson 5)

> *"You want to draw a car, make it twice as big, then move it 10 units to the right. What is the correct order of operations?"*

A. Scale then Translate
B. Translate then Scale
C. Rotate then Scale
D. Translate then Rotate

Type just the letter (A, B, C, or D).

You've got this — one letter! 👊

a

Great try again! You chose **A (Scale then Translate)**.

That is actually **correct** for this specific question! ✅

Let me explain why, because the "golden rule" I mentioned earlier needs a little nuance.

✅ Why A is correct here

You want to:

1. Make the car **twice as big** (Scale by 2)
2. **Then** move it 10 units right (Translate by 10)

If you **translate first**, then scale, the movement distance *also* gets scaled (you'd move 20 units instead of 10).
So for your goal: **Scale → Translate** is right.

The fuller golden rule (more accurate):

If you want to...	Order
Scale around object's center, then move	Scale → Translate

If you want to...	Order
Move, then scale around world origin	Translate → Scale
Rotate around own center, then move	Rotate → Translate
Move, then rotate around world origin	Translate → Rotate

> **Key insight:** Order matters because each transformation happens *relative to the current coordinate system*.

📋 Cheat Sheet – Lesson 5 (Transformations)

Term	Simple Definition	OpenGL Function
Translation	Move object by (tx, ty, tz)	`glTranslatef(tx, ty, tz)`
Rotation	Spin object by angle A around axis	`glRotatef(A, x, y, z)`
Scaling	Resize by (sx, sy, sz)	`glScalef(sx, sy, sz)`
Homogeneous coordinates	Add W coordinate to make translation a matrix multiply	—
Affine transformation	Preserves parallel lines (translate, rotate, scale, shear)	—
Order of operations	Last one in code happens first to the object	—

🚀 Moving to Lesson 6: 3D Objects

Now we go from 2D shapes to **3D surfaces**.

Core concept: Parametric surfaces

Just like a curve uses **t** (one parameter), a surface uses **(u, v)** — two parameters.

Example: A sphere of radius r

```
text

x = r * cos(u) * cos(v)
y = r * sin(u) * cos(v)
z = r * sin(v)
```

Where u goes 0 to 2π, v goes -π/2 to π/2.

Three ways to represent a 3D object:

Method	Description	Example
Explicit	z = f(x, y)	Height map (terrain)
Parametric	(x, y, z) = f(u, v)	Sphere, torus
Implicit	F(x, y, z) = 0	Sphere: $x^2+y^2+z^2 = r^2$

Triangle Meshes

Most common in games: a surface made of thousands of tiny triangles.

- **Vertex list** = all points
- **Face list** = which 3 vertices form each triangle

🧠 Active Recall Question #6 (Lesson 6)

> *"What is the difference between an explicit surface (z = f(x,y)) and a parametric surface?"*

A. Explicit can only be flat; parametric can be curved

B. Explicit gives only one z per (x,y); parametric can loop back on itself (e.g., sphere)

C. Explicit uses triangles; parametric uses quads

D. There is no difference

Type A, B, C, or D.

One letter — you're doing great! 🎯

a

You chose **A** again! You're being consistent — I appreciate that.

A is not quite correct for this one, but the mistake teaches us something important. Let me explain.

✅ Correct Answer: B

> *"Explicit gives only one z per (x,y); parametric can loop back on itself (e.g., sphere)"*

Why B is correct (and why A is wrong)

Surface Type	Limitation	Example
Explicit `z = f(x,y)`	One z value for each (x,y) — cannot make a sphere (would need two z values for same x,y)	Terrain, hills
Parametric `(x,y,z) = f(u,v)`	Can loop back — multiple (x,y) pairs can share same z	Sphere, donut (torus)

Simple analogy

- **Explicit** = a blanket draped over a bed (one height per spot)
- **Parametric** = a beach ball (wraps around completely)

Why A is wrong

Explicit surfaces *can* be curved (hills, waves) — they're not just flat. The real limit is they can't be **closed** like a sphere.

📋 Cheat Sheet – Lesson 6 (3D Objects)

Term	Simple Definition
Explicit surface	z = f(x,y) — one height per (x,y)
Parametric surface	(x,y,z) = f(u,v) — can curve back on itself
Implicit surface	F(x,y,z)=0 — great for ray tracing
Triangle mesh	Surface made of many tiny triangles
Vertex list	All unique points stored once
Face list	Which 3 vertices make each triangle
Surface normal	Perpendicular vector — tells which way surface faces
Spherical coordinates	(r, θ, φ) — great for skyboxes, planets

🚀 Moving to Lesson 7: Camera Models

This is where we finally become **directors** of our 3D world.

The Pinhole Camera Model (simplest)

Imagine a box with a tiny hole on one side and film on the opposite side. Light enters the hole and projects an **upside-down** image.

In computer graphics:

- Camera at origin (0,0,0)
- Looks down the **negative Z-axis** (OpenGL convention)
- Image plane in front of camera

Two main projection types

Projection	What it does	When to use
Perspective	Far objects appear smaller	Games, realistic rendering
Parallel (Orthographic)	Objects stay same size regardless of distance	CAD, blueprints, 2D games

Analogy

- **Perspective** = human eye (train tracks meet at horizon)
- **Orthographic** = architect's blueprint (walls parallel forever)

🧠 Active Recall Question #7 (Lesson 7)

> *"In OpenGL's default camera setup, which direction does the camera look?"*

A. Positive X-axis
B. Positive Y-axis
C. Positive Z-axis
D. Negative Z-axis

Type A, B, C, or D.

One letter — you're building real knowledge now 🎬

a

You chose **A** (Positive X-axis). That's not correct — but again, that's totally fine! Let me correct you gently.

✅ Correct Answer: D (Negative Z-axis)

In OpenGL's default camera setup:

- Camera is at the **origin** (0,0,0)
- It looks down the **negative Z-axis** (toward -∞)

Quick memory trick:

> OpenGL camera = "Z-negative is forward"

Why?

This follows a **right-handed coordinate system** where:

- +X = right
- +Y = up
- **-Z = forward** (into the screen)

So when you draw something at z = -5, it's **in front** of the camera.
If you draw at z = +5, it's **behind** the camera (invisible).

📋 Cheat Sheet – Lesson 7 (Camera Models)

Term	Simple Definition
Pinhole camera	Tiny hole instead of lens — infinite depth of field
Thin lens model	Uses lens to focus light — realistic but complex
Focal length	Distance from lens to focused image
Perspective projection	Far objects appear smaller (realistic)

Term	Simple Definition
Parallel (orthographic) projection	Objects same size regardless of distance (blueprints)
Vanishing point	Where parallel lines appear to meet (perspective)
OpenGL camera direction	Looks down negative Z-axis
glFrustum()	Sets perspective projection in OpenGL
glOrtho()	Sets orthographic projection in OpenGL

🚀 Moving to Lesson 8: Visibility, Lighting & Shading

Now things get **beautiful** — this is where graphics starts to look real.

Core concept 1: Hidden Surface Removal (Z-buffer)

Without this, you'd see *through* walls to objects behind them.

How Z-buffer works:

- Each pixel stores its **depth** (distance from camera)
- When drawing a new pixel, compare its depth to stored depth
- If closer → draw it and update depth
- If farther → ignore it

In OpenGL: `glEnable(GL_DEPTH_TEST);`

Core concept 2: Reflection Model (Phong)

Objects reflect light in three ways:

Component	Source	Example
Ambient	Bounced light everywhere	Shadow area still dimly visible
Diffuse	Light scatters evenly	Matte paint, clay, paper
Specular	Mirror-like reflection	Metal, wet surface, plastic

Core concept 3: Shading Types

Shading	How it works	Looks like
Flat	One color per polygon	Faceted, blocky (old PS1 games)
Gouraud	Color at vertices, interpolated across face	Smooth but low-specular
Phong	Normals interpolated, lighting per pixel	Very smooth, high quality

🧠 Active Recall Question #8 (Lesson 8)

> *"What is the purpose of the Z-buffer in computer graphics?"*

A. Store